

Proposal for Emoji: Maze

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Identification

Suggested name: Maze

Suggested keywords: labyrinth; puzzle; mouse; path; navigation; learning; memory; choice; complexity; research

Suggested category: Activities - game

Suggested sort location: Near Puzzle Piece in the game subgroup.

Required Example Images

Size	Color	Black and white
18x18		
72x72		

The paradigm is a mouse navigating a square labyrinth with broad corridors, a visible entrance, and a visible exit. The mouse-maze scene identifies both the physical puzzle and the act of finding a route. It is not a specific laboratory apparatus, map, floor plan, user-interface icon, logo, or exact puzzle.

The example images are original vector artwork created for this proposal and released under CC0 1.0. Editable SVG sources and the license are included in the public packet:

<https://github.com/ShuhanCS/medicalemoji/tree/codex/eligible-2026-slate/submissions/v1.5.0/maze/images>

<https://github.com/ShuhanCS/medicalemoji/blob/codex/eligible-2026-slate/submissions/v1.5.0/ARTWORK-LICENSE.md>

Factors for Inclusion

A. Multiple meanings and usages

Maze names both a physical puzzle and a common metaphor for complexity, confusion, difficult navigation, and searching for a way through a problem. It can represent paper and book puzzles, garden and hedge mazes, corn mazes, escape games, level design, route planning, problem-solving exercises, and the experience of being lost in an unfamiliar place or process.

The mouse-maze image also directly supports learning, memory, decision-making, behavioral research, and education. Those uses do not limit the character to a laboratory: a mouse navigating corridors is an iconic visual shorthand for any maze, choice among paths, trial and error, and searching for an exit.

B. Use in sequences

- Maze + thinking face: working through a difficult problem.
- Maze + map or compass: finding a route or navigating a confusing place.
- Maze + person running: maze race, escape game, or obstacle challenge.
- Maze + microscope: behavioral experiment or laboratory research.
- Maze + brain: learning, memory, cognition, or decision-making.
- Maze + school: classroom puzzle or learning exercise.
- Maze + check mark: puzzle solved or way out found.

These are ordinary emoji combinations; no standardized sequence is requested.

C. Breaks new ground

Yes. Puzzle Piece represents one interlocking piece, not a navigable network with multiple routes and dead ends. Map represents geography, and Compass represents orientation. The mouse-maze scene adds the action of navigating a bounded path puzzle, choosing among alternatives, encountering dead ends, learning from prior routes, and finding a way through complexity.

D. Distinctiveness

The enclosing square, thick right-angle walls, entrance and exit gaps, mouse body, round ears, pointed nose, and tail produce a recognizable scene. The corridors and mouse remain simplified for 18x18. The image differs from a QR code because it uses a few broad continuous walls, and it differs from Map because it has no folds, roads, labels, or location marks.

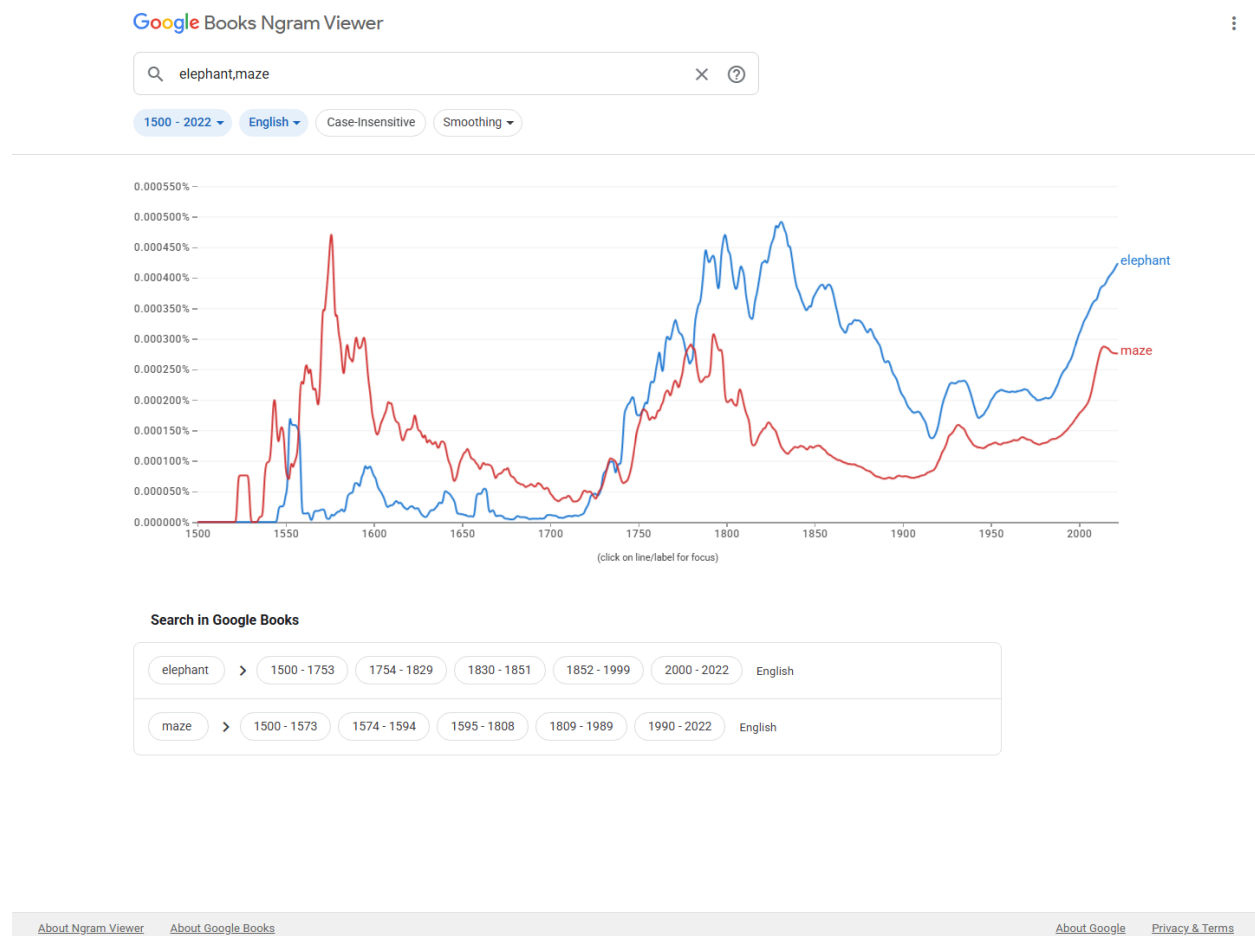
E. Expected usage level

The Google Books comparison provides a durable historical signal. For 2018-2022, the smoothed English corpus average for `maze` is approximately $2.77\text{e-}6$, about 67 percent of `elephant` ($4.14\text{e-}6$). The curve shows sustained use over centuries and a pronounced rise in the late twentieth and early twenty-first centuries.

Evidence completion notice: This draft must not be filed until fresh screenshots are inserted for Google Search, Google Video Search, Google Trends Web Search, and Google Trends Image Search. The current automated Google session was blocked by a CAPTCHA/rate limit; no result count or chart has been invented.

Evidence	Current packet result	Reproducible URL
Google Search	Fresh screenshot and visible result count required	https://www.google.com/search?q=maze&hl=en&num=10&pws=0
Google Video Search	Fresh screenshot and visible result count required	https://www.google.com/search?tbm=vid&q=maze&hl=en&num=10&pws=0
Google Trends Web Search	Fresh Worldwide, 2004-present screenshot against <code>elephant</code> required	https://trends.google.com/trends/explore?date=all&q=elephant,maze
Google Trends Image Search	Fresh Worldwide, 2008-present screenshot against <code>elephant</code> required	https://trends.google.com/trends/explore?date=all_2008&gprop=images&q=elephant,maze
Google Books Ngram Viewer	Included; <code>maze</code> is approximately 0.67x <code>elephant</code> in the 2018-2022 smoothed English average	https://books.google.com/ngrams/graph?content=elephant%2Cmaze&year_start=1500&year_end=2022&corpus=en&smoothing=3

Google Books Ngram Viewer



F. Completeness

Not applicable. Maze is independently useful and is not proposed to complete a fixed collection of games, puzzles, navigation tools, educational activities, or research apparatuses.

G. Compatibility

Not applicable. The proposal does not depend on a legacy carrier emoji or a high-frequency pictograph in a particular existing service.

Factors for Exclusion

A. Already represented

No existing emoji expresses a mouse navigating a bounded network of branching paths and dead ends. Mouse plus Puzzle Piece does not show route choice, and Mouse plus Map reads as an

animal and geographic map. Those sequences ask the reader to infer a scene that the mouse-maze paradigm communicates directly.

B. Overly specific

The proposal covers mazes and labyrinths as a broad class. The mouse is an iconic navigator and does not restrict the meaning to a named apparatus, species, experiment, protocol, game level, corridor count, solution, building, garden, or cultural site.

C. Open-ended

Maze is not one arbitrary puzzle design among many. The mouse navigating branching paths supports learning, memory, navigation, complexity, confusion, choice, and escape meanings that a crossword, jigsaw, riddle, or board game does not. The proposal does not imply that each puzzle type or research apparatus should be encoded.

D. Transient

Mazes and labyrinths have a long cultural history, and the Ngram curve demonstrates sustained published use. Their physical and metaphorical meanings do not depend on a current app, game, campaign, or technology.

E. Justified only by existing emoji

The case does not rest on Puzzle Piece, Map, or Compass already being encoded. Those comparisons define the remaining semantic gap; Maze stands on its own multiple meanings, distinctive form, frequency evidence, and durability.

Other Information

The public status record lists declined Maze rows with `Date Submitted` values of 2018-04-12 and 2020-12-18. The present proposal is outside the four-year resubmission period by the 2026-07-31 deadline. It uses new original mouse-maze artwork. Research, learning, and memory are concrete uses; the proposal does not rely on neuroscience representation, disease awareness, or another cause as a selection factor.

Vendors should preserve a simple mouse with a visible body, ears, nose, and tail inside broad corridors. They should keep the entrance and exit open and avoid a brain, cage, researcher, directional arrow, written label, or identifiable commercial or real-world maze.

Official Unicode proposal guidance:

<https://www.unicode.org/emoji/proposals.html>